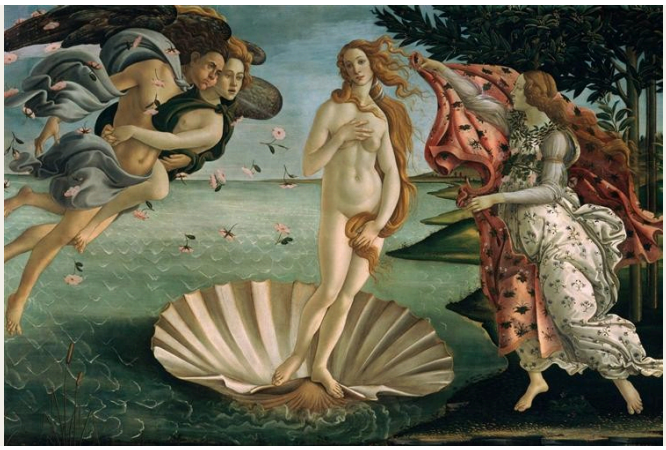
FLORENCE, ITALY

Uffizi Galleries: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings in which posture, clothing and proportion carry the argument.



Botticelli's Venus is arriving, not being born: the winds bring her towards a waiting cloak. That distinction gives the picture a direction. Across this selection, bodies do similarly practical work. They establish authority, bring a sacred event close, arrest a battle or make a killing physically comprehensible. A bent elbow may explain more than a label naming a style.

The repeated Madonnas are useful comparisons rather than interruptions between famous pictures. A throne can hold a figure apart from the surrounding world; an angel's glance can bring that world closer. Follow these changes without treating every departure from ordinary anatomy as a mistake waiting to be corrected.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/uffizi

The selection · 20

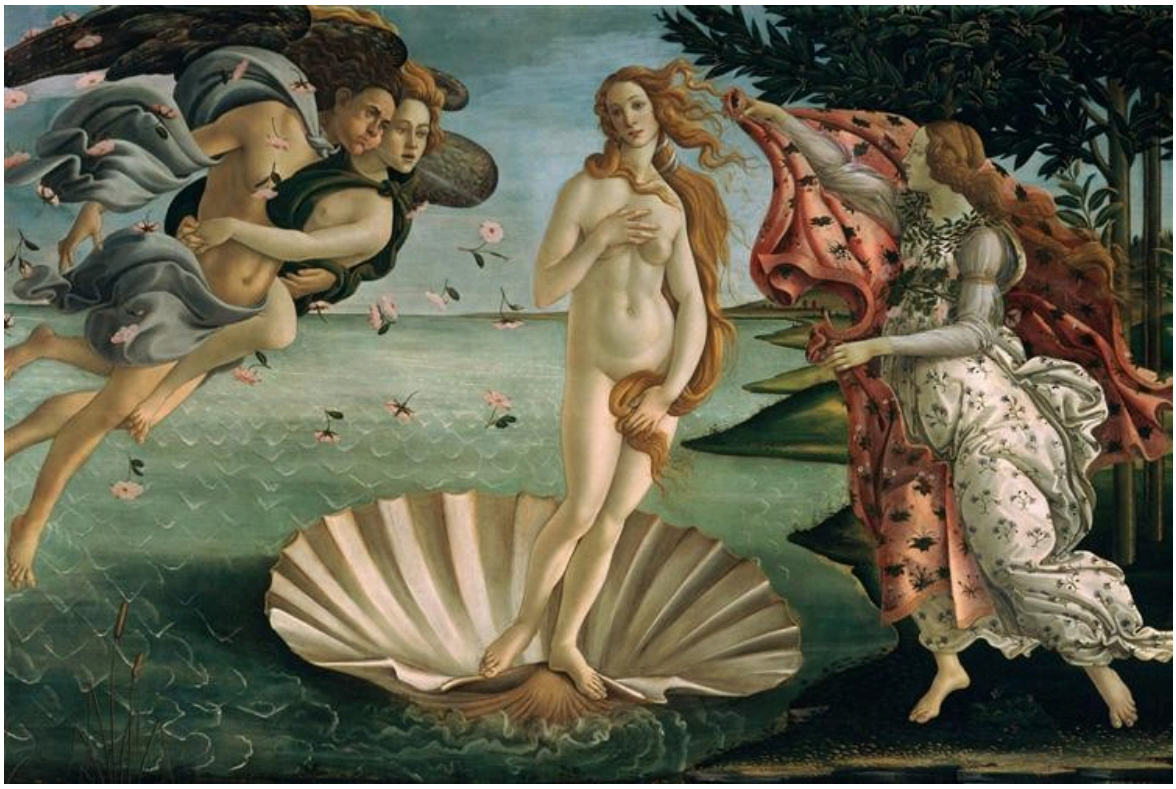
1. The Birth of Venus
   Sandro Botticelli · c. 1485
2. The Annunciation
   Leonardo da Vinci · 1472
3. Medusa
   Caravaggio · 1597
4. Venus of Urbino
   Titian · 1538
5. Ognissanti Madonna
   Giotto di Bondone · 1306-1310
6. Adoration of the Magi
   Gentile da Fabriano · 1423
7. Judith Beheading Holofernes
   Artemisia Gentileschi · c. 1620
8. Rucellai Madonna
   Duccio · 1285
9. Adoration of the Magi
   Andrea Mantegna · 1461
10. Primavera
    Sandro Botticelli · 1478-1482
11. Battista Sforza
    Piero della Francesca · 1465
12. The Battle of San Romano: The Unhorsing of Bernardino della Ciarda
    Paolo Uccello · 1438
13. Fortitude
    Sandro Botticelli · c. 1470
14. Madonna and Child with Two Angels
    Filippo Lippi · c. 1460–1465
15. Harbour with the Villa Medici
    Claude Lorrain · 1637
16. Lucrezia Panciatichi
    Bronzino · 1540
17. Madonna and Child with Saints Dionysius, Dominic, Clement and Thomas Aquinas
    Domenico Ghirlandaio · 1486
18. Madonna and Child with Six Saints
    Sandro Botticelli · c. 1470
19. Madonna and Child with Saint John the Baptist and Saint Sebastian
    Pietro Perugino · 1493
20. Madonna of the Long Neck
    Parmigianino · 1534 - 1540

01 / 20

The Birth of Venus

Sandro Botticelli

c. 1485 · Tempera on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Sandro Botticelli. The Birth of Venus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The shell has reached the shore, but the movement continues through Venus's hair and the cloak held out to receive her. Botticelli gives the arriving figure little of the weight a body would need to stand securely there. The long contours keep her connected to wind and fabric, suspended between the journey and its end.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1890 n. 878

02 / 20

The Annunciation

Leonardo da Vinci

1472 · Oil , panel , tempera , wood · Uffizi Galleries



Annunciation. WikiArt; Leonardo da Vinci. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lectern and garden wall give the encounter firm boundaries. Beyond them, Leonardo allows water and mountains to become progressively less distinct. Mary and the angel therefore meet in a space that feels close and measurable, while the world behind them escapes that clarity. Nearness and distance are painted differently, rather than merely made different sizes.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Medusa

Caravaggio

1597 · Uffizi Galleries



Caravaggio. Medusa. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The open mouth registers a cry that the severed head can no longer sustain. Blood below and snakes above leave almost no neutral passage around the face. Caravaggio painted on a convex shield: the support projects towards the viewer even as the depicted head seems caught in an uncertain space within it. The object complicates the illusion.

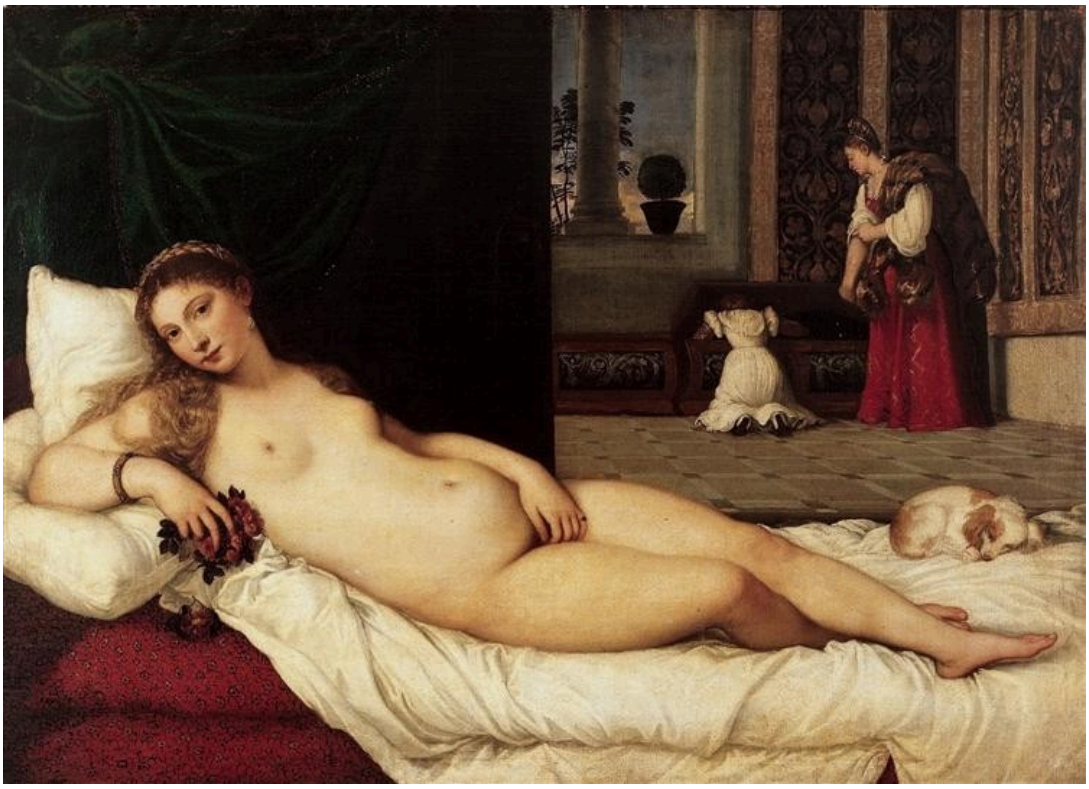
Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Venus of Urbino

Titian

1538 · Oil on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Titian. Venus of Urbino. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Titian gives this Venus something Botticelli's lacks: a household continuing behind her. The maids attend to a chest, and the dog sleeps while the reclining woman looks out. Those different states of attention make the gaze unusually direct. The Uffizi reads the domestic details in relation to marriage, placing the exposed body within a social setting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1890 no.1437

05 / 20

Ognissanti Madonna

Giotto di Bondone

1306-1310 · Uffizi Galleries



Giotto di Bondone. Madonna in Maest (Ognissanti Madonna). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Mary's greater scale establishes her sacred rank before any gesture does. Yet Giotto also makes the robe contain a seated body, supported by a throne with architectural depth. Neither effect cancels the other. The image can assert a hierarchy while allowing the central figure to occupy space with an intelligible physical weight.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Adoration of the Magi

Gentile da Fabriano

1423 · Uffizi Galleries



Gentile da Fabriano. Adoration of the Magi. Image credit: Gentile da Fabriano. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The procession is already under way in the distant hills before it arrives at the child. Gentile da Fabriano turns looking across the painting into a way of following that journey. The elaborate clothes and horses crowd its destination, but the landscape prevents the encounter from becoming an isolated ceremonial group: these visitors have come from somewhere.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 8364

07 / 20

Judith Beheading Holofernes

Artemisia Gentileschi

c. 1620 · Oil on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Artemisia Gentileschi, Judith Beheading Holofernes. Uffizi Galleries, Florence. Reproduction via Wikimedia Commons (PD-Art). Source reproduction has a levels adjustment. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

Follow the arms before trying to separate the figures. Judith and her attendant have different jobs, and their crossed limbs show how tightly the action depends on both women. Artemisia makes resistance and effort visible through braced bodies. The violence is not explained by a symbol or an expression alone; it has a difficult physical procedure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1890 no. 1567

08 / 20

Rucellai Madonna

Duccio

1285 · Uffizi Galleries



Duccio. Madonna Rucellai. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The gold edging of Mary's robe gives the eye a route through the large blue shape. Its turns suggest where the body changes direction without dissolving the ceremonial clarity of the figure. Duccio's angels support the throne rather than share an ordinary room with its occupant. Delicate handling and emphatic hierarchy belong to the same image.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Adoration of the Magi

Andrea Mantegna

1461 · Tempera on panel · Uffizi Galleries



Adoration of the Magi, central panel from the Altarpiece. WikiArt; Andrea Mantegna. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Mantegna's rocky opening makes a narrow destination for the approaching visitors. The procession has to negotiate the terrain before reaching Mary and the child. Compare Gentile's crowded, richly furnished arrival: here the rock carries much of the organising work, enclosing the meeting while the thin route behind it preserves the distance travelled.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Primavera

Sandro Botticelli

1478-1482 · Uffizi Galleries



Sandro Botticelli. The Spring. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Begin with the changing kinds of movement: pursuit at the right, a dance elsewhere, a more stationary centre. Botticelli keeps the groups distinct even as repeated contours connect them beneath the trees. The painting's larger meanings remain debated. Its gestures offer a firmer first foothold than a key that claims to translate every figure into one settled message.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Battista Sforza

Piero della Francesca

1465 · Tempera on panel · Uffizi Galleries



Portrait of Battista Sforza. WikiArt; Piero della Francesca. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The profile refuses the exchange of glances offered by Titian's Venus. Battista's face is sharply bounded, while the landscape behind it extends far beyond the sitter's immediate space. Piero makes stillness a form of public presentation. Jewels and the patterned bodice specify status, but the unyielding outline gives the portrait its compositional authority.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

The Battle of San Romano: The Unhorsing of Bernardino della Ciarda

Paolo Uccello

1438 · Tempera on wood · Uffizi Galleries



Victory over Bernardino della Ciarda. WikiArt; Paolo Uccello. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Fallen weapons divide the ground beneath the colliding horses. Their clear directions let the eye measure a space whose occupants are engaged in violent disorder. Uccello keeps both systems visible: the battle as bodily confusion and the painting as an arrangement of lines. The ordered surface does not make the subject any less brutal.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Fortitude

Sandro Botticelli

c. 1470 · Tempera on panel · Uffizi Galleries



Sandro Botticelli. Fortitude. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/sandro-botticelli/fortitude-1470-1 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Botticelli gives a virtue a seat, armour and a contained gesture. Fortitude does not need to demonstrate her strength by striking an opponent. The supported body and firm grasp establish the quality through readiness rather than action. Broad red cloth supplies a different kind of surface against which the harder armour can register.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Madonna and Child with Two Angels

Filippo Lippi

c. 1460–1465 · Uffizi Galleries



Filippo Lippi. Madonna and Child. Image credit: Filippo Lippi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

One angel turns away from the devotional exchange and smiles out of the picture. That small departure changes the group's relationship with its audience. Mary keeps her hands joined, the child remains supported, and the sacred arrangement holds; Filippo Lippi nonetheless leaves a point at which an ordinary, sociable glance crosses its boundary.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1598

15 / 20

Harbour with the Villa Medici

Claude Lorrain

1637 · Oil on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Claude Lorrain. Harbour with Villa Medici. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/claude-lorrain/harbour-with-villa-medici-1637 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The buildings and ships supply substantial forms, but their placement opens a passage towards the harbour's light. Claude's small foreground workers establish a human scale without taking possession of the scene. This imagined port offers a useful reversal of the figure paintings: people occupy a world organised primarily around distance rather than around them.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Lucrezia Panciatichi

Bronzino

1540 · Oil on panel · Uffizi Galleries



Bronzino. Lucrezia Panciatichi. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/agnolo-bronzino/lucrezia-panciatichi-1540 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The book gives a resting place to the hand; jewellery and dark trim break the broad expanse of red satin. Bronzino distributes these details around a face that remains remarkably still. The portrait makes social presentation legible through controlled surfaces. It supplies evidence of dress and bearing, not unrestricted access to the sitter's private character.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Madonna and Child with Saints Dionysius, Dominic, Clement and Thomas Aquinas

Domenico Ghirlandaio

1486 · Oil on panel · Uffizi Galleries



Madonna and Child enthroned with St. Dionysius, Aeropagita, Domenic, Clement and Thomas Aquinas. WikiArt; Domenico Ghirlandaio. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The architectural recess establishes a centre that the saints can share without standing in identical poses. Ghirlandaio varies their heights through kneeling and standing, while the floor and arches hold the assembly together. The setting performs an important task: separate figures become occupants of a coherent space rather than a row of isolated sacred portraits.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Madonna and Child with Six Saints

Sandro Botticelli

c. 1470 · Tempera · Uffizi Galleries



Sandro Botticelli. Madonna and Child with Six Saints. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/sandro-botticelli/madonna-and-child-with-six-saints · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The kneeling saints occupy the nearest part of the patterned floor. They help negotiate the distance to the elevated Virgin and child, while turns of heads lead the eye between the figures. In this Botticelli, small changes of posture give a still group its structure. Compare the more conspicuous movements of *Primavera*: here a quiet pose can do the compositional work.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Madonna and Child with Saint John the Baptist and Saint Sebastian

Pietro Perugino

1493 · Oil on wood · Uffizi Galleries



Madonna and Child with St. John the Baptist and St. Sebastian. WikiArt; Pietro Perugino. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The saints stand apart, with open intervals around their bodies. Perugino makes those gaps as easy to read as the figures themselves. Repeated arches reinforce the separation without breaking the group into unrelated parts. Where other altarpieces gather attention through a crowd, this arrangement gives each presence room and keeps the approach to Mary clear.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Madonna of the Long Neck

Parmigianino

1534 - 1540 · Oil on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Parmigianino. Madonna with the Long Neck. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/parmigianino/madonna-with-the-long-neck-1540 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The crowded angels and the open space beside the column refuse an even distribution. Mary's extended neck, long fingers and unusually proportioned child continue the imbalance within the bodies themselves. Parmigianino gives no single comfortable scale against which to settle everything. After the measured intervals of Perugino, the picture makes the usefulness of stable proportion conspicuous by withdrawing it.

Object source · Open artwork

Choose a comparison, not a checklist

Try following one problem through three works: how a hand holds, how clothing describes a body, or how a throne creates distance. The collection selection is not a room-by-room route. Check the Uffizi's current notices and individual display information before arranging a visit around a particular painting.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s collected writings discuss proportion, movement, light and the arrangement of figures. They offer practical questions to bring back to the paintings here, including his own Annunciation.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
